Princess and the Hustler: Key Quotations

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Princess & The Hustler: Key Theme Quotations

Here, we will analyse key quotes grouped according to the following themes:

- **Belonging and identity**
- **Family**
- **Hope and ambition**
- **Activism and protest**

Having an extensive knowledge and understanding of the play will mean that you are able to answer any question that comes up in your exam to a high level, with quality evidence.

Belonging and identity

Race

> **"An' I never plan to be nuh strange fruit"** — Wendell, Act 1, Scene 7

What the quotation means

- Wendell explains to Junior that his former partner, Lorna's mother, developed mental health problems that led her to wrongfully accuse him of abusive behaviour:
  - This in turn led to the community threatening to harm Wendell
- "Strange fruit" refers to **lynching**

Analysis

- The disturbing image of "strange fruit" is used to show how vulnerable and unsafe Wendell's racial identity has made him:

Stuck on something?
Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.
Got it

mistreatment at the time
    - That Wendell "never plans" to end up that way illustrates his determination and a savviness about how to navigate the discrimination he faces

> **"I'm not Black like you. I'm only half. Half of everything"** — Lorna, Act 2, Scene 3

What the quotation means

- Following a racially motivated attack on Junior, Princess suggests that she and Lorna should hide
- Lorna, who is mixed race, argues that she doesn't need to hide, claiming she is "not black" in the way that Princess is

Analysis

- Lorna associates blackness with danger and oppression:
    - This further alienates Princess, who is unable to escape from those negative associations in the way Lorna can
    - This episode also **foreshadows** the end of Act 2, in which Princess has lost faith in her own sense of self, to the point that she "destroys her cupboard world"
- Lorna, like Princess, feels a lack of belonging in the middle act of the play:
    - The word "half" echoes Lorna's own use of the **derogatory** term "half-caste" in the same scene, suggesting she has difficulty embracing her mixed heritage

Help me understand

Gender

> **"Because my hair is as pretty as a doll's she said"** — Lorna, Act 2, Scene 3

What the quotation means

- Lorna tells Mavis and Wendell that Margot said her hair looks like the doll's

Analysis

- By using the doll, which is white, as a reference point for female beauty standards, Margot unwittingly marginalises Princess.
- Hair becomes a **motif**:
    - While Lorna parrots Margot's idea of her hair being pretty, Princess cuts much of her own hair off using a pair of scissors at the end of Act 2
        - This could be seen as a **symbolic** rejection of her own femininity

> **"…if you come from a queen then you must be a…"** — Mavis
>
> **"A princess!"** — Princess, Act 3, Scene 5

What the quotations mean

- Mavis, who presents herself as the "queen" in this scene, reminds Princess of her dignity and self worth

Analysis

- Both "queen" and "princess" **connote** status and pride:
  - This is especially poignant at the end of the play, which at times shows Mavis and her family as relatively poor:
    - For example, in Act 1, Scene 1, when Mavis notes that "nobody [is] ordering curtains" at that time of year
- The **lineal** connection between "queen" and "princess" suggests the idea of inheritance: what Princess arguably inherits from her mother in this scene is female pride

Family

> **"Let me take a picture of us. All of us…"** — Wendell Junior, Act 3, Scene 5

What the quotation means

- Wendell Junior includes all of the family members, including Wendell and Lorna, in his family photograph

Analysis

- The family photograph is **symbolic** of unity, emphasised by the phrase "all of us"
- Photographs are static: Wendell Junior has changed and he is more willing to accept his father:
  - The act of taking the picture could represent a desire to make permanent this version of his family

Paired quotations:

> **"[Mavis] holds [Princess] tighter than she's ever held her before"** — Stage direction, Act 2, Scene 3

>

> Scene 5

What the quotations mean

- In both of these scenes, in which Princess is feeling vulnerable, the stage directions show Princess and Mavis hugging each other tightly

Analysis

- Mavis is a protective and loving mother:
  - In both of the quotations above, the adverb "tighter" is used to show that Mavis is attuned to Princess' emotions and is able to support her in her most vulnerable moments

Hope and ambition

Paired quotations:

> ''**"My crown invisible but it there…"** — Mavis, Act 3, Scene 5

> **"You have to crown me the winner"** — Princess, Act 3, Scene 6

What the quotations mean

- The image of a crown is used to suggest power and dignity:
  - Mavis uses the image to model to Princess that she is proud of who she is, and in the final scene, Princess, instructs Wendell to place a "crown" on her head

Analysis

- Crowns serve as a **motif** from the beginning of the play and represent Princess' aspirations to be seen as beautiful
- For Princess, by the end of the play, that **motif** becomes connected with the sense of dignity and self-worth that her mother instils in her, even if she doesn't actually go to the beauty pageant in Weston-super-Mare

>

What the quotation means

- Mavis articulates her modest hopes that her children will thrive

Analysis

- Mavis shows again here that she is selfless: her "quiet dreams" are not for herself, but for her children:
  - "dem alive" emphasises the optimistic nature of this part of the play, where the hope that her family will be reunited parallels the hope of protesters that the **colour bar** will be lifted in Bristol
- Dreams are a **motif** in the play: Princess, Wendell and Mavis all refer to their dreams and aspirations for the future

Activism and protest

> **"Wi done being mindful"** — Wendell, Act 2, Scene 2

What the quotation means

- In a tense exchange with Margot, in which she explains that Jamaican immigrants should be "mindful" of the communities into which they integrate, Wendell pushes back by saying that his community are "done being mindful"

Analysis

- Wendell begins to champion the cause of the bus boycott in Act 2: his character transitions from being an individualistic "hustler", to someone who is outward-looking and politically engaged
- His response to Margot is terse, and somewhat forceful:
  - The adjective "done" reinforces Wendell's growing frustration with the treatment of black people in England and reflects his growing activism and impatience for change
  - Although Margot is well-meaning and close to Mavis and her family, she is dismissive of the bus boycott and expresses casually racist ideas in this scene:
    - Wendell aligns himself with a worthy cause in this scene and this contrast reflects well on his character

> **"Yuh see dem men dat make dis happen, dem heroes… it ar victory for… Every kinda man dem"** —

What the quotation means

- As victory for the protesters and the lifting of the colour bar in Bristol becomes increasingly likely, Wendell praises the architects of those protests as "heroes"

Analysis

- Both "victory" and "heroes' have **connotations** of celebration and create a joyous tone that is sustained throughout the final scenes
- Wendell is probably referring to the organisers of the boycott (such as Paul Stephenson) when he refers to the "men dat make dis happen":
  - Though the success of the protests also reflect well on Wendell himself, who has been intensely involved in them also

> **"Di hotta di battle, di sweeta di victory!"** — Family, Act 3, Scene 5

What the quotation means

- Mavis leads her family in a call-and-response style chant to celebrate the success of the Bristol Bus Boycott

Analysis

- The **metaphor** of "battle" emphasises the intensity of the struggle for black rights in Bristol:
  - The **juxtaposition** of "battle" and "victory" **vindicates** the family's efforts in struggling for justice for black workers

- The call-and-response nature of this quotation, with Mavis saying the line first, and her family repeating it back, illustrates how the protest has unified them

Source

Odimba, Chinonyerem. (2019) *Princess & The Hustler*. Nick Hern Books

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